

picked up a hockey stick 13 years ago, is now one of India's most promising forwards.

"My family and neighbours thought I was just playing hockey for fun and that I would eventually return to wrestling," said Deepika, who has since scored 27 goals in 56 matches for the national team.

However, she was serious about the sport. Two years later, Malik told her that with focus and hard work, she could become an exceptional player. It didn't take long for her to prove him right. At the Sub-Junior Nationals in Hisar in 2018, she netted 18 goals, leading Haryana to the title and earning the 'Best Player of the Tournament' award. Soon after, she was called up to the junior national camp.

Tough initiation

When captain and ace forward Rani Rampal was sidelined with a hamstring injury following India's historic fourth-place finish at the Tokyo Olympics, newly appointed coach Janneke Schopman introduced Deepika to the senior squad during the FIH Pro League 2021-22 season. The youngster, however, failed to score in her six appearances and was omitted from the Commonwealth Games squad that went on to win bronze in Birmingham in 2022.

A year later, during India's victorious Junior Asia Cup campaign in Oman, Deepika amassed seven goals in six matches, four of them from penalty corners (PCs). This performance earned her a spot in the squad for the Asian Games in Hangzhou. In India's tournament opener, she finally opened her international account, scoring a PC against Singapore.

"Coach Malik first introduced me to drag-flicking. He told me that, coming from a family of wrestlers, I already had the power. But he also

warned me about the higher risk of injury," she said.

Once in the senior camp, Rupinder Pal Singh, one of India's finest drag-flickers and a bronze medallist at Tokyo 2020, taught her the nuances of the skill.

Deepika learned a tough lesson at the FIH Olympic Qualifiers 2024 in Ranchi. On the eve of the tournament, Schopman noted that opposition coaches viewed Deepika's drag-flick as a serious threat. However, she managed to convert just one PC in five games as India finished fourth, failing to qualify for the Paris Olympics.

"That experience taught me the importance of staying calm as a drag-flicker. Not every attempt results in a goal, but at the same time, not every shot is a miss," she reflected.

Learning from the best

During the inaugural Women's Hockey India League (HIL) in January, she received invaluable tips from Dutch star Yibbi Jansen, currently the best drag-flicker in women's hockey.

"She told me how she adjusts her speed and positions her feet. She also suggested watching videos of opposition rushers for better preparation," Deepika said.

Her drag-flicking prowess took centre stage during India's successful defence of the Women's Asian Champions Trophy in Rajgir last year, where she finished as the tournament's top scorer with 11 goals, six from PCs. Her performances drew praise from Indian men's captain Harmanpreet Singh, who posted on X (formerly Twitter): "A special shoutout to Deepika – from one drag-flicker to another, you're destined for greatness!"

Deepika ended 2024 as the third-highest female goalscorer worldwide with 17 goals.

Recognising her consistent performances, Hockey India recently honoured her with the Asunta Lakra Award for Upcoming Player of the Year (Women's Under-21), while goalkeeper Savita Punia won the Balbir Singh Sr. Award for Player of the Year for the third time.

A photograph of a young Deepika garlanding Savita at a felicitation function years ago resurfaced on social media soon after the awards ceremony. "That day, she had just returned from an

